

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

PEOPLE

BURNOUT AND WORKLOAD

How often people feel burned out, pressure in Germany and Europe, what the WHO counts as burnout, Gallup's five factors, six areas of worklife, and a card for a talk about workload.



28%

of full-time employees feel burned out at work very often or always, in a 2019 study of 12,658.

GALLUP, 2020

INSIDE

COVER STORY

More than one in four

PAGE 03

THE MODEL

What the WHO counts

PAGE 05

TOOL OF THE WEEK

The workload talk

PAGE 08

NO. 29 · PEOPLE

In this issue

Burnout is often treated as a personal problem. The WHO places it in the job: chronic stress at work that has not been managed. This issue looks at how common it is, what goes with it, and what a manager can change in the work.

In a 2019 Gallup study, 28% of full-time employees felt burned out very often or always. In Germany 48% often work under strong deadline or performance pressure; in Europe more than 40% report severe time pressure. The WHO counts burnout as an occupational phenomenon, not a medical condition. Gallup links it most strongly to unfair treatment, unmanageable workload, unclear roles, little support from the manager and unreasonable time pressure; Maslach and Leiter name six areas where job and person may not fit.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

03 COVER STORY
More than one in four

04 THE NUMBERS
Pressure in Germany and Europe

05 THE MODEL
What the WHO counts as burnout

06 WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS
What goes with burnout

07 HOW IT IS MEASURED
Where the job does not fit

08 TOOL OF THE WEEK
The workload talk

09 SOURCES
Sources and method

HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure

Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading

Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice

The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

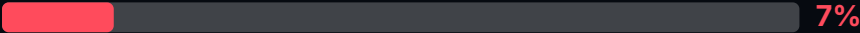
COVER STORY

More than one in four

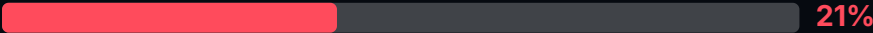
In a 2019 study Gallup asked 12,658 full-time employees how often they feel burned out at work. 28% answered very often or always; 76% at least sometimes.

HOW OFTEN FULL-TIME EMPLOYEES FEEL BURNED OUT AT WORK (2019)

Always



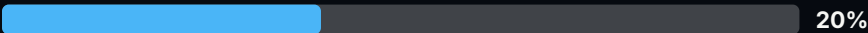
Very often



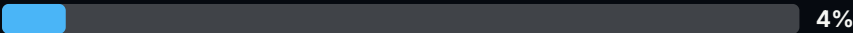
Sometimes



Rarely



Never



A 2018 Gallup study of about 7,500 full-time employees found 23% very often or always, and 44% sometimes. The samples differ, so the two figures do not make a trend.

OUR READING

The largest group is the 48% who answer sometimes. Burnout shows up in degrees, not only in rare cases.

Sources: Gallup, 2020; Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018

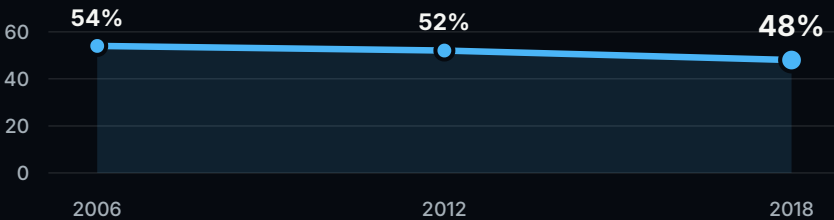
Self-reports, not diagnoses; the texts we saw do not name the country of the samples.

THE NUMBERS

Pressure in Germany and Europe

The German BIBB/BAuA survey of 2018 asked over 20,000 employed people about their work. 48% often work under strong deadline or performance pressure, fewer than in 2006 and 2012.

OFTEN UNDER STRONG DEADLINE OR PERFORMANCE PRESSURE, GERMANY



Of those exposed, 67% feel burdened by it, up from 65% in 2012. In spring 2025 EU-OSHA asked over 28,000 workers in the EU, Iceland, Norway and Switzerland by telephone:

> 40%

report severe time pressure

≈ 1 in 3

feel their efforts go unnoticed

≈ 30%

report poor communication or cooperation

Sources: Bundesanstalt für Arbeitsschutz und Arbeitsmedizin (BAuA), 2020; EU-OSHA, 2025

Self-reports; the German figures are from 2018, and EU-OSHA gives only rounded values. For Albania we have no comparable data on burnout.

THE MODEL

What the WHO counts as burnout

In May 2019 the World Health Organization included burn-out in its International Classification of Diseases, ICD-11, as an occupational phenomenon. “It is not classified as a medical condition.”

It describes a syndrome resulting from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed, with three dimensions:

01**Exhaustion**

feelings of energy
depletion or exhaustion

02**Distance**

more mental distance
from one's job, or
negativism or cynicism
about it

03**Efficacy**

reduced professional
efficacy

It refers only to work and should not be used for other areas of life. In ICD-11 it has the code QD85, among problems associated with employment, in the chapter on factors influencing health status, not among the diseases. ICD-11 came into effect on 1 January 2022.

OUR READING

The definition points at work, not at the person: stress at work that has not been managed. Managing the work is a manager's job; diagnosing a person is not.

Sources: World Health Organization, 2019; World Health Organization, 2025

The current ICD-11 entry words the third dimension as a sense of ineffectiveness and lack of accomplishment. This issue describes a definition and gives no medical advice.

[More in the essay](#)[Leading people without losing the person](#)

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

What goes with burnout

In 2018 Ben Wigert and Sangeeta Agrawal of Gallup named the five factors most strongly linked to burnout among about 7,500 full-time employees.

Gallup's order, 2018

1. unfair treatment at work
2. unmanageable workload
3. lack of role clarity
4. lack of communication and support from the manager
5. unreasonable time pressure

2.3x

as likely to report high burnout, for those often treated unfairly at work

≈ 70%

less likely to feel burned out regularly, for those who feel supported by their manager

70%

less likely to report high burnout, for those who often or always have enough time for all their work

Employees who felt burned out were 63% more likely to take a sick day and 2.6 times as likely to be actively looking for another job.

OUR READING

All five factors are decided at work. That is where a manager can look first.

Sources: Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018; Gallup, 2020

Associations from self-reports, not proof of cause. In 2020 Gallup put unclear communication from managers and lack of manager support in third and fourth place.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Where the job does not fit

Christina Maslach and Michael Leiter describe six areas of worklife in which a person and the job can be mismatched. The bigger the mismatch, the more likely burnout; the better the match, the more likely engagement.

01**Workload**

Can the work be done in the time there is?

02**Control**

Who decides how the work is done?

03**Reward**

Is the effort seen and rewarded?

04**Community**

Do people help each other?

05**Fairness**

Are work and decisions shared fairly?

06**Values**

Does the work fit what people think is right?

A meta-analysis by Eean Crawford, Jeffery LePine and Bruce Rich found that job demands go with more burnout, and job resources with less burnout and more engagement. Demands that people see as hindrances go with less engagement; demands they see as challenges, with more.

Sources: Christina Maslach & Michael P. Leiter, *World Psychiatry*, 2016; Eean R. Crawford, Jeffery A. LePine & Bruce L. Rich, *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 2010

The questions are the editors', after the six areas. Correlations, not proof of cause; Maslach and Leiter note that few studies evaluate interventions.

TOOL OF THE WEEK

The workload talk

Fifteen minutes, one to one, every few weeks. The talk is about the work, not about health: the manager listens, asks, and writes down one change.

01 Load what is on the list this week, and what could wait

02 Time where deadlines collide, and who set them

03 Decisions what you can decide yourself, and where you wait for others

04 Fairness where work or credit feels unevenly shared

05 Support what I can take off, decide or ask for on your behalf

06 One change what, who, by when; look at it again next time

Sources: Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018; Christina Maslach & Michael P. Leiter, World Psychiatry, 2016

A practice proposed by the editors, after Gallup's five factors (2018) and the six areas of worklife. It does not replace medical help.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Gallup's Perspective on Employee Burnout: Causes and Cures

Gallup, 2020

<https://www.gallup.com/file/workplace/282668/Gallups%20Perspective%20on%20Employee%20Burnout%20Causes%20and%20Cures.pdf>

OSH Pulse 2025: Occupational safety and health in the era of climate and digital change

EU-OSHA, 2025

<https://osha.europa.eu/en/publications/osh-pulse-2025-occupational-safety-and-health-era-climate-and-digital-change>

Understanding the burnout experience: recent research and its implications for psychiatry

Christina Maslach & Michael P. Leiter, World Psychiatry, 2016

<https://doi.org/10.1002/wps.20311>

Linking job demands and resources to employee engagement and burnout: A theoretical extension and meta-analytic test

Eean R. Crawford, Jeffery A. LePine & Bruce L. Rich, Journal of Applied Psychology, 2010

<https://doi.org/10.1037/a0019364>

Burn-out an "occupational phenomenon": International Classification of Diseases

World Health Organization, 2019

<https://www.who.int/news/item/28-05-2019-burn-out-an-occupational-phenomenon-international-classification-of-diseases>

Stressreport Deutschland 2019

Bundesanstalt für Arbeitsschutz und Arbeitsmedizin (BAuA), 2020

<https://www.baua.de/EN/Service/Publications/Report/Stress-report-2019>

Employee Burnout, Part 1: The 5 Main Causes

Ben Wigert & Sangeeta Agrawal, Gallup, 2018

<https://www.gallup.com/workplace/237059/employee-burnout-part-main-causes.aspx>

ICD-11 for Mortality and Morbidity Statistics (2025-01): QD85 Burnout

World Health Organization, 2025

<https://icd.who.int/browse/2025-01/mms/en#129180281>

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked "via". The editors' interpretation is marked "Our reading". Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every week, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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